



Mary Kom shares a warm moment with Sunil Gavaskar, while Sakshi Malik owns her space in front of the Sportstar Aces backdrop. PICS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

was defined by dramatic comebacks, including victories over Sweden's Johanna Mattsson, Mongolia's Purevdorjiin Orkhon and Kyrgyzstan's Aisuluu Tynybekova in the bronze-medal bout.

That medal, secured in the dying seconds of the contest, ended India's anxious wait for a podium finish at the Games and instantly became one of the most dramatic moments in the country's Olympic history. She received the award from former Indian women's team captain Jhulan Goswami and Saumitra Srivastava, Director, Marketing at IOCL.

Looking back on that defining match, Sakshi recalled the emotions of the final moments.

"Thanks to all the jury members

and the organisers for honouring me with this award. When an athlete receives an award, it becomes a very memorable moment," Sakshi said after receiving the award.

"That match (bronze-medal match) is something I will never forget. In the last seven or eight seconds, I was trailing, and that final move earned me the medal. I couldn't believe it. That moment can't really be captured in words. I was excited, very happy, and in tears at the same time. It was a mix of emotions. That medal was very special.

"(On how matters are settled at home, since her husband is also a wrestler) Our sport is a combat sport. Once we get off the mat, we

are so tired that there is no energy left to fight at home," she said with a laugh.

Sakshi also reflected on how dramatically the ecosystem around Indian wrestling has changed since she first stepped onto the mat.

"When we started wrestling, there were hardly any facilities, but even then, we trained very hard. If someone from a middle-class family like mine can do it, then today's athletes certainly can. Now, there are academies everywhere, and they offer much better facilities. You can train in all weather conditions. Just focus on your target. If you want to reach the Olympics and win a medal, you can do it. Stay focused and keep working hard."